

166 CE

BEGINNING OF THE MARCOMANNIC WARS

By the 2nd century CE, Roman frontiers came under increasing pressure from barbarians. In 166 CE, Germanic tribes invaded the province of Pannonia; two years later, the Marcomanni, who had settled near the Danube in Bohemia, surged into Italy. Emperor Marcus Aurelius fought them back and campaigned across the Danube, but it took 14 years of hard fighting before the Marcomannic wars were finally concluded.

▷ Romans clash with Germanic tribes, detail from Portonaccio Sarcophagus



140 CE

169 CE An outbreak of plague in the Roman Empire kills Emperor Lucius Verus

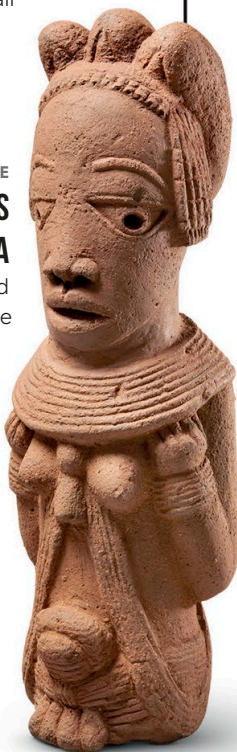
143–161 CE The Roman frontier in Britain is temporarily moved north to the Antonine Wall

150 CE

NOK CULTURE FLOURISHES IN WEST AFRICA

Arising in the fertile region around the Benue river in central Nigeria, the Nok culture developed iron-smelting, and produced terracotta figurines of humans and animals of great sophistication. Despite dominating a large region, within 50 years their culture had collapsed, possibly through overpopulation or invasion by neighbouring groups.

▷ Nok terracotta figurine



▽ Temple complex at Hatra, Iraq



160 CE

KINGDOM OF HATRA AT ITS PEAK

One of the first Arab states outside the Arabian peninsula, the kingdom of Hatra, in modern northern Iraq, reached its peak in the 160s CE, growing rich from its position astride a major caravan route. It resisted Roman attempts to conquer it in 117 CE and 199 CE, but finally fell to the Sasanian ruler Shapur I in 240 CE.